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DJIA 47885.97 ▼ 228.29 0.47% NASDAQ 22693.32 ▼ 1.8% STOXX 600 579.79 ▼ 0.002% 10-YR. TREAS. ▼ 1/32, yield 4.150% OIL \$55.94 ▲ \$0.67 GOLD \$4,347.50 ▲ \$43.00 EURO \$1.1741 YEN 155.70

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Bankers and investors** looking at Medline's successful debut as a public company are bracing for a slate of blockbuster IPOs in 2026, and wondering if the market can handle the torrent. **A1**
- ◆ **Warner Bros. Discovery** urged its shareholders to reject Paramount Skydance's hostile takeover bid, saying the Ellison family-led offer was inadequate on multiple levels. **A1**
- ◆ **Weaker tech stocks** helped pull U.S. indexes lower, with the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow retreating 1.2%, 1.8% and 0.5%, respectively. **B10**
- ◆ **The Justice Department** indicted Adderall startup Done Global a month after its founder and top doctor were convicted of a conspiracy to distribute controlled substances. **B1**
- ◆ **The Oscars will leave** ABC and appear on YouTube beginning in 2029 under a rights deal the video platform struck with the Academy for the awards show. **B1**
- ◆ **BP said Chief Executive** Murray Auchincloss is stepping down as head of the oil company and named an outsider as his successor. **B3**
- ◆ **Elliott has built** a stake of over \$1 billion in Lululemon and is bringing a potential CEO candidate to the struggling athletic apparel retailer. **B1**
- ◆ **Activist investor Irenic** has built a stake of over 3% in Integer and is urging the medical-device outsourcing company to refresh its board and consider a sale. **B3**
- ◆ **Weyerhaeuser said it** launched a venture to turn runty trees and sawdust from its mills into a replacement for coal used in steel making. **B1**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Four vulnerable** House Republicans rebelled against Speaker Mike Johnson and backed a Democratic effort to force a vote on extending Affordable Care Act subsidies. **A1**
- ◆ **The \$8 billion black** market for Venezuelan oil—a lifeline for the Maduro regime—is in jeopardy as the U.S. targets ships already sanctioned by the Treasury Department. **A1**
- ◆ **The Senate approved** a sweeping defense-policy package despite alarm over a provision that rolls back safety measures put in place after a fatal midair collision over the Potomac River in January. **A4**
- ◆ **The U.S. government** accepted fault for the midair collision, which killed 67 people near Washington, D.C. **A4**
- ◆ **Trump defended** his handling of the economy during a rare prime-time speech and announced a \$1,776 "warrior dividend" check for active-duty servicemembers. **A2**
- ◆ **A federal appeals court** allowed Trump to continue deploying National Guard units in Washington, D.C., at least temporarily. **A3**
- ◆ **Dan Bongino said he** is stepping down as the FBI's deputy director after a nine-month tenure in which he clashed with the Justice Department leadership and the bureau's workforce. **A4**
- ◆ **FCC Chair Brendan Carr** told a Senate oversight hearing that the commission isn't an independent agency, contradicting a description that, until then, had been featured on its website. **A5**
- ◆ **Died: Peter Arnett, 91**, Pulitzer Prize-winning reporter. **A2**

CONTENTS	Market Data..... B6
Arts in Review..... A12	Opinion..... A13-15
Business & Finance B2-31	Personal Journal A9-10
Business News..... B5	Sports..... A16
Crossword..... A10	Technology & Media B4
Heard on Street..... B11	U.S. News..... A2-5
Markets..... B10	World News..... A6



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Somber Return Home for Slain Guardsmen



EVAN VUCCI/ASSOCIATED PRESS

PAID RESPECTS: President Donald Trump saluted as the bodies of two Iowa guardsmen, Sgt. Edgar Brian Torres-Tovar and Sgt. William Nathaniel Howard, as well as interpreter Ayad Mansoor Sakat, arrived at Dover Air Force Base in Delaware on Wednesday. They were killed in an attack in eastern Syria, where U.S. troops are part of a coalition fighting Islamic State.

Wall Street Gets Early Taste Of Hot Year Expected for IPOs

Shares of Medline begin trading in the biggest new stock listing since 2021

By CORRIE DRIEBUSCH

Wall Street is getting a glimpse of what could be the biggest year ever for IPOs in the U.S.

After four years of choppy market for new stock offerings, bankers and investors are bracing for a slate of blockbuster listings in 2026—and wondering if the market can handle the torrent. Medline's stock-market debut

but Wednesday could offer an early gauge of whether investors will be up for it. The medical-supply company raised roughly \$6.3 billion in its stock offering, making it the biggest initial public offering in the U.S. since Rivian's stock offering in 2021.

Medline's stock closed at \$41, up 41% from its \$29 IPO price. The stock is listed on the Nasdaq Stock Market under the symbol MDLN.

"We're the largest company no one's ever heard of," said Jim Boyle, chief executive of Medline. He said he and his team have spent the past year and a half educating the investment community ahead of the

stock offering.

The offering could help set the stage for some of the most highly anticipated IPOs, with rocket maker SpaceX, artificial-intelligence company Anthropic and mortgage giants Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac among the companies looking at listings in 2026.

It isn't just high-profile private companies. Bankers say their teams have been busy in recent weeks pitching companies to be a lead adviser on their IPOs next year, marking a pickup in activity.

Many startups had eschewed going public in recent years. "I'm not sure that's entirely true anymore," said Mag-

dalena Heinrich, head of U.S. technology equity capital markets at Bank of America.

Bankers are hoping Medline, which is backed by Blackstone, Carlyle and Hellman & Friedman, helps close out a positive year for IPOs.

More than two dozen technology companies have gone public so far this year, which bankers see as a healthy sign after years of anemic tech offerings. Many of these companies, including software company Figma and crypto firm Circle Internet Group, jumped in their debuts, though their shares have since pared gains.

Overall, U.S. IPOs this year *Please turn to page A2*

Blockade By the U.S. Hamstrings Venezuelan Oil Strategy

Venezuela used the same playbook as Russia and Iran to get around crippling American sanctions on its oil industry, tapping a shadowy fleet of aging vessels to carry crude to customers.

By *Benoit Faucon, Costas Paris and Shelby Holliday*

President Trump's partial oil blockade threatens to devastate this black market, which U.S. officials say lines Venezuelan leader Nicolás Maduro's pockets and props up the impoverished country's fragile economy.

U.S. officials said the military would be going after a network of ships already sanctioned by the Treasury Department. Such tankers account for about 70% of Venezuela's oil exports, mostly sent to Asian buyers who pay in cryptocurrencies, Venezuelan economist Asdrubal Oliveros said on the country's public radio Wednesday.

Losing access to that network of ships would reduce Venezuelan revenue by some \$8 billion a year, Oliveros estimated.

Some sanctioned tankers have already turned around to avoid the U.S. Navy flotilla in the Caribbean, which has al-

Please turn to page A8

◆ **Oil prices climb as blockade** raises supply risks..... **B10**

INSIDE



SPORTS

The NFL knows it has an officiating problem, but labor issues are a sticking point. **A16**



BUSINESS & FINANCE

The art market is staging a comeback, boosting the world's top auction houses. **B1**

How to Sell a Romance Novel: Put the Characters in Skates

* * *

Book market is flooded with steamy books about hockey; 'Puck and Prejudice'

By JEANNE WHALEN

Rachel Reid was just trying to entertain herself while waiting for her child to fall asleep when she started jotting down a tale of love and lust between rival hockey players. She had no idea she had just struck literary gold.

People can't get enough hockey romance. The book market is flooded with steamy novels about love on the ice. There's "Hockey With Benefits," "Body Check" and "Puck and Prejudice," about a goalie who accidentally travels back in time to Regency-era England and falls for a friend of

Jane Austen.

The books have a global following on TikTok, and in places without much hockey or even ice, including Australia and Spain. "Heated Rivalry," Reid's book about male hockey lovers, was adapted for television and has quickly become one of the most watched shows on HBO Max. Another novel in the genre is being turned into a series for Amazon's Prime Video.

The phenomenon has sparked curiosity and confusion in the literary world and beyond.

Other sports are full of *Please turn to page A10*

The War on Poverty Failed Appalachia

McDowell County isn't waiting for government to restore its fortunes

By DAN FROSCH

WAR, W.Va.—Carolyn Owens was 9 years old when her family became one of the first in America to get food stamps.

Her father could no longer work in the coal mines that pock the mountains here after an injury. He'd wait at the local government office to collect food coupons, part of a program launched by

John F. Kennedy in 1961 to help alleviate the shocking poverty he witnessed campaigning across Appalachia.

Owens would walk home from school to find peanut-butter sandwiches with a sliver of banana waiting for her and her 10 brothers and sisters. "Those sandwiches were like ice cream for us," said Owens, now 73.

In the decades since, the *Please turn to page A8*

Warner Bros. Presses Ellison on Bid Terms

By LAUREN THOMAS AND JOE FLINT

Warner Bros. Discovery sent a message to Larry Ellison: If you want to buy our company, sign on the dotted line yourself.

Warner urged its shareholders Wednesday morning to reject Paramount Skydance's hostile takeover bid, saying the Ellison family-led offer was inadequate on multiple levels compared with that of rival Netflix.

Warner said it had lingering concerns about the financing, including the use of an Ellison family trust to backstop the deal. The company wants Ellison to give a stronger personal guarantee that he, not

an opaque trust, is fully committed to the \$77.9 billion bid.

The billionaire founder of Oracle is among the world's richest men, even briefly holding the title of the very richest this year. Yet his son David is fighting over Warner just as Oracle's shares are under pressure over concerns about its bets on the artificial-intelligence boom. The stock fell another 5% on Wednesday on reports of a potential financial partner spinning a data center Oracle was building.

Paramount's \$77.9 billion bid is a higher price for Warner than Netflix's \$72 billion offer. But Warner is saying it isn't that simple. Netflix is buying only Warner's studio *Please turn to page A5*

Revolt In GOP On Health Exposes Party Rift

Lawmakers fearing lapse in enhanced subsidies sign on to House vote on ACA

WASHINGTON—Four vulnerable House Republicans rebelled against Speaker Mike Johnson (R., La.) and backed a Democratic effort to force a

By *Siobhan Hughes, Lindsay Wise and Richard Rubin*

vote on extending Affordable Care Act subsidies, exposing GOP fractures over surging healthcare costs headed into next year's midterm elections.

Rep. Mike Lawler (R., N.Y.) joined three Republicans from Pennsylvania swing districts—Reps. Brian Fitzpatrick, Rob Bresnahan and Ryan Mackenzie—in signing a petition led by House Minority Leader Hakeem Jeffries (D., N.Y.) that would force a vote on a three-year extension of enhanced ACA subsidies. The lawmakers acted after the GOP leaders blocked votes on compromise measures aimed at extending and trimming the subsidies, saying their voters' needs were urgent.

The split among Republicans shows the challenges confronting the party, with about 20 million people on ACA plans facing higher costs due to the expiration of the enhanced subsidies at the end of this month. Republicans are hoping to hang onto a thin majority in the House, but the party is divided over whether to rescue the subsidies, which Democrats passed in 2021 with no GOP support.

"I am pissed for the American people. This is absolute bulls—," said Lawler about the standoff in Congress. "Everyone has a responsibility to serve their district, to serve *Please turn to page A4*